



Measured departure: A marshal notes timings as 4x4s disappear into forest tracks, signalling the start of another punishing stage at the Orange 4x4 Fury in Dambuk. NIGAMANTH P.

When the mountains push back

In Dambuk's citrus heartland, the JK Tyre Orange 4x4 Fury unfolds not as a race against rivals, but as a **prolonged negotiation** with rivers, rocks, and the limits of machinery.

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In the Lower Dibang Valley of Arunachal Pradesh, the quiet mountain town of Dambuk undergoes a high-octane transformation every December. Celebrated as India's 'Orange Bowl' for its sprawling citrus orchards, the region turns into a premier destination for off-road enthusiasts during the JK Tyre Orange 4x4 Fury.

Recognised as one of India's most gruelling endurance challenges, the Fury forgoes traditional high-speed racing in favour of a battle against the unpredictable.

Competitors navigate treacherous, boulder-strewn riverbeds along the Lohit, Dibang, and Sisiri rivers. While

the vehicles are street-legal and properly registered, the smooth transit sections between stages offer the only respite from punishing dust and deep sand.

This year's edition introduced two major upgrades: a dedicated companion app for real-time navigation and timing, and an influx of international participation. Teams from Malaysia and Thailand joined the Stock category. Lhakpa Tsering, the event's president and a seasoned rally veteran, is focused on globalising Indian off-roading. "For the first time in this edition, we have teams participating from abroad," Tsering noted. "We've been experimenting with the competition to make it more appealing. Anyone with a passion for off-roading can take part in the event."

The competition is divided into two distinct classes. The Pro-Modified Class features purpose-built machines with custom chassis, massive suspension travel, and hydraulic winches designed to tackle extreme obstacles, including the midnight prologue stage.

Conversely, the Stock Class is reserved for production vehicles such as the Mahindra Thar or Maruti Suzuki Jimny. With limited modifications allowed, including changes to tyres and suspension, drivers must rely on technical precision and momentum to conquer terrain that Pro-Mod machines simply power through.

But entering the Pro-Mod category comes with a staggering price tag. Winner Chethan Chengappa, hailing from the rugged hills of Coorg, acknowledges that passion is only half the requirement. "It's not cheap," he admits.

"A machine like this would make you poorer by at least ₹ 45 to 60 lakh. We have a participant here who has spent over a crore on his car. So, Pro-Mod requires not just passion but a deep pocket," he said.

This year reflected a clash of styles. While Rakshit Katta, a medical professional from Bengaluru, secured second place in Pro-Mod through months of intensive terrain research, winner Chengappa leaned on the expertise of teammates from NorthEast India, whose innate understanding of the region's tricky riverbeds proved decisive.

While success at the 4x4 Fury demands relentless endurance, the reward lies partly in the contrast offered by the evenings. Once the technical demands of the day were met, the Orange Festival's music replaced the sound of revving engines. As Adnan Sami, Sunidhi Chauhan, and local artistes performed in the heart of the orange orchards, the same landscape that punished machines by day became a shared gathering space by night, a reminder that in Dambuk, the land always sets the terms.

The writer was at the event by invitation of JK Tyre Motorsports.